THE KUKI RETORT
Kuki women checking vehicles at the entry to Churachandpur





mainly women, that assembled in Imphal to dissuade him from submitting his resignation. The central BJP leadership is apprehensive that ousting Biren might be seen as punishment for taking action against the Kukis, which will alienate the electorally influential Meiteis. "He is now representing the Meitei cause," says a senior BJP leader, who is a member of the national executive. "People are not bothered about his governance record any more. They are emotionally attached to Meitei pride, of which he has become the face and first soldier." Biren also has the support of at least 15 of the 32 BJP MLAs, who have been with him since their Congress days. Dismissing him may cause a vertical split in the party and end up in the BJP losing one of its crown jewels in the Northeast.

That the Naga community has remained neutral in this conflict has also gone in Biren's favour. His return to power a second consecutive time last year is attributed to, among other things, his outreach programme, 'Go to Hills', which aims to take the benefits of welfare schemes to the doorsteps of people in the tribal-dominated hills. Biren became the first CM in 15 years to be accorded a red-carpet welcome by the local Naga communities in Ukhrul district, the hub of Naga politics in the state. A cordial relationship with the Nagas has a salubrious impact on peace in neighbouring Nagaland too.

The Union government is also unlikely to yield to the Kuki demand for a division of Manipur. Such a move will only encourage similar demands from other parts of the country. The other workable solution is to give more autonomy to the Hill District Councils; some experts suggest autonomous rule under the 6th Schedule in Kuki-dominated areas. The experiment has been hugely successful in Assam's Bodo-dominated districts. However, it will be tough to convince people in the valley about either alternative. Meanwhile, both sides have dug in their heels. While Kuki groups have said they will stop at nothing less than a separate state or UT, Biren has said he will "fight against this until the last drop of his blood".

With no immediate solution in sight, most experts are unanimous that the authorities need to first disarm the state. Of the 4,000 looted weapons, only 1,000 have been recovered or returned. "The violence could go on for long because the entire state is armed. There should be a massive drive to rid the state of illegal arms. Even the licensed ones must be seized till normalcy returns," says a senior army officer. The Union government, for the moment, is biding its time, as any drastic action could fan the fire again. A better option is to tire out the fighting groups. Already, there are feelers from both sides seeking exit routes. There is a realisation that the current situation—complete geographical isolation minus any communication—is not viable in the long run. The home ministry has initiated talks with community leaders from both sides and expects a breakthrough soon. The prime minister is personally monitoring every development. "On some days, he is briefed up to three times in 24 hours," says a top source. Both the Centre and the state government have to work all backdoor channels to provide both communities honourable and workable solutions. It's a task easier said than done and needs honest political will. That's something in short supply in Manipur. ■